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Many people suffer an allergic reaction to certain sulfites, including those that are commonly added to wine as preservatives. However, since there are several winemakers who add sulfites to none of the wines they produce, people who would like to drink wine but are allergic to sulfites can drink wines produced by these winemakers without risking an allergic reaction to sulfites.

Which of the following is an assumption on which the argument depends?

A. These winemakers have been able to duplicate the preservative effect produced by adding sulfites by means that do not involve adding any potentially allergenic substances to their wine.

B. Not all forms of sulfite are equally likely to produce the allergic reaction.

C. Wine is the only beverage to which sulfites are commonly added.

D. Apart from sulfites, there are no substances commonly present in wine that give rise to an allergic reaction.

E. Sulfites are not naturally present in the wines produced by these winemakers in amounts large enough to produce an allergic reaction in someone who drinks these wines.

Argument Construction

Situation People who are allergic to certain sulfites can avoid risking an allergic reaction by drinking wine from one of the several producers that does not add sulfites.

Reasoning *On what assumption does the argument depend?* Drinking wine to which no sulfites have been *added* will not prevent exposure to sulfites if, for instance, sulfites occur naturally in wines. In particular, if the wines that do not have sulfites added have sulfites present naturally in quantities sufficient to produce an allergic reaction, drinking these wines will not result in an allergic reaction. The argument therefore depends on assuming that this is not the case.

A. The argument does not require this because the conclusion does not address allergic reactions to substances other than sulfites.

B. The argument specifically refers to "certain sulfites" producing allergic reactions. It is entirely compatible with certain other forms of sulfites not producing allergic reactions in anyone.

C. This is irrelevant. The argument does not claim that one can avoid having an allergic reaction to sulfites *from any source* just by restricting one's wine consumption to those varieties to which no sulfites have been added.

D. Once again, the argument's conclusion does not address allergic reactions to substances other than sulfites in wine.

E. **Correct.** As explained in the Reasoning section above, the argument relies on the assumption that sulfites are not naturally present, in quantities sufficient to cause allergic reactions, in the wines to which no sulfites are added. If this assumption is not made, then the fact that no sulfites are added to certain wines is not a good reason to believe that people with sulfite allergies who consume the wines will not have an allergic reaction; if there are enough sulfites that naturally occur in the wine, people who consume the wine may well have an allergic reaction despite the fact that no sulfites have been added.

The correct answer is E.

•

A new law gives ownership of patents—documents providing exclusive right to make and sell an invention—to universities, not the government, when those patents result from government-sponsored university research. Administrators at Logos University plan to sell any patents they acquire to corporations in order to fund programs to improve undergraduate teaching.

Which of the following, if true, would cast the most doubt on the viability of the college administrators' plan described above?

A. Profit-making corporations interested in developing products based on patents held by universities are likely to try to serve as exclusive sponsors of ongoing university research projects.

B. Corporate sponsors of research in university facilities are entitled to tax credits under new federal tax-code guidelines.

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guidelines.

C. Research scientists at Logos University have few or no teaching responsibilities and participate little if at all in the undergraduate programs in their field.

D. Government-sponsored research conducted at Logos University for the most part duplicates research already completed by several profit-making corporations.

E. Logos University is unlikely to attract corporate sponsorship of its scientific research.

Evaluation of a Plan

Situation Universities own the patents resulting from government-sponsored research at their institutions. One university plans to sell its patents to corporations and use the proceeds to fund a program to improve teaching.

Reasoning *What would cast doubt on the university's plan?* The plan assumes that the university has been granted, and/or will be granted, patents for its inventions; that there will be a market for its patents; and that corporations will want to buy them. What might make this untrue? For example, the university's inventions might have no practical value or might be useful only for government agencies, and if some of the corporations have already done the same or similar research, they will likely not be prospective buyers of the university's patents.

A. This point is irrelevant to the plan to sell patents in order to fund a program.

B. The university plans to sell the patents to the corporations, not to invite the corporations to sponsor research.

C. This point is irrelevant to the university's plan to sell off patents since the plan does not specify that the research scientists will be involved in the programs to improve undergraduate teaching.

D. **Correct.** This statement properly identifies a factor that casts doubt on the university's plan. The plan presupposes that corporations will want to buy the rights to the inventions. If some of the corporations have already done the same or similar research, they would likely have developed ways of achieving what the university's inventions promise to achieve. In the case of potential future patents, they might even have already patented the inventions that the university would develop, in which case the university would be unable to patent them. Or the corporations might have developed similar, but not identical, inventions that serve the same purpose. In such cases, they probably would not need the university's inventions.

E. The plan concerns selling patents resulting from government-sponsored research, not attracting corporate sponsorship for research.

The correct answer is D.

•

Since it has become known that **several of a bank's top executives have been buying shares in their own bank**, the bank's depositors, who had been worried by rumors that the bank faced impending financial collapse, have been greatly relieved. They reason that, since top executives evidently have faith in the bank's financial soundness, those worrisome rumors must be false. Such reasoning might well be overoptimistic, however, since **corporate executives have been known to buy shares in their own company in a calculated attempt to dispel negative rumors about the company's health.**

In the argument given, the two **boldfaced** portions play which of the following roles?

A. The first describes evidence that has been taken as supporting a conclusion; the second gives a reason for questioning that support.

B. The first describes evidence that has been taken as supporting a conclusion; the second states a contrary conclusion that is the main conclusion of the argument.

C. The first provides evidence in support of the main conclusion of the argument; the second states that conclusion.

D. The first describes the circumstance that the argument as a whole seeks to explain; the second gives the explanation that the argument seeks to establish.

E. The first describes the circumstance that the argument as a whole seeks to explain; the second provides evidence in support of the explanation that the argument seeks to establish.

Argument Evaluation

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Argument Evaluation

Situation Top executives at a bank that has been rumored to be in financial trouble have been buying shares in the bank. Bank depositors see this as a good sign, because they believe that it indicates that the executives have faith in the bank. However, corporate executives sometimes do this just to dispel rumors about a company's health.

Reasoning *What is the role that the two **boldfaced** portions play in the argument?* The first **boldfaced** portion states that bank executives are buying bank shares, which the passage indicates is taken by bank depositors to be evidence of the executives' faith in the bank; in other words, the bank depositors take the fact that the executives are buying shares in the bank as supporting the conclusion that the executives have faith in the bank and thus that the rumors that the bank is facing financial collapse are wrong. The passage then tells us what some have inferred from this (namely, that worrisome rumors about the bank's impending financial collapse are false). Finally, the passage offers in the second **boldfaced** portion evidence that undermines this inference: corporate executives have sometimes bought shares in their own companies just to dispel negative rumors, presumably whether the rumors are true or not.

A. **Correct.** This option correctly identifies the roles played by the **boldfaced** portions. As discussed in the Reasoning section above, the bank depositors have drawn the conclusion from the first **boldfaced** portion that the bank's finances are sound, but the second **boldfaced** portion is presented to call their conclusion into question.

B. This correctly describes the first portion's role, but the second portion is not offered as a conclusion—no evidence is given for it; rather, it is evidence for something else.

C. The second portion is not offered as a conclusion; no evidence is given for it.

D. The second portion is not itself offered as an explanation of why these bank executives are investing in the bank; if it were, that would mean that the bank executives are doing so *because* corporate executives are known to do such things in a calculated effort to dispel worries. Furthermore, the argument does not conclude that this other explanation (which the **boldfaced** portion points to) is correct, only that the one inferred by depositors may not be.

E. The argument is not so much seeking to establish an explanation of its own as it is trying to undermine that inferred by the depositors.

The correct answer is A.

•

Between 1980 and 2000, the sea otter population of the Aleutian Islands declined precipitously. There were no signs of disease or malnutrition, so there was probably an increase in the number of otters being eaten by predators. Orcas will eat otters when seals, their normal prey, are unavailable, and the Aleutian Islands seal population declined dramatically in the 1980s. Therefore, orcas were most likely the immediate cause of the otter population decline.

Which of the following, if true, most strengthens the argument?

A. The population of sea urchins, the main food of sea otters, has increased since the sea otter population declined.

B. Seals do not eat sea otters, nor do they compete with sea otters for food.

C. Most of the surviving sea otters live in a bay that is inaccessible to orcas.

D. The population of orcas in the Aleutian Islands has declined since the 1980s.

E. An increase in commercial fishing near the Aleutian Islands in the 1980s caused a slight decline in the population of the fish that seals use for food.

Argument Evaluation

Situation A sea otter population declined even though there were no signs of disease or malnutrition. The local seal population also declined. Orcas eat otters when seals are unavailable, and thus are probably the cause of the decline in the otter population.

Reasoning *What would be evidence that predation by orcas reduced the sea otter population?* Disease and malnutrition are ruled out as alternative explanations of the decline in the sea otter population. The

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malnutrition are ruled out as alternative explanations of the decline in the sea otter population. The argument could be further strengthened by casting doubt on other possible explanations, such as predation by other animals, or by presenting observations that predation of otters by orcas would help to explain.

A. Regardless of whether or not orcas ate the sea otters, the sea urchin population would most likely have increased when the population of sea otters preying on them decreased.

B. Because the seal population declined during the initial years of the otter population decline, predation by and competition with seals were already implausible explanations of the otter population decline.

C. **Correct.** Orcas eating most of the accessible otters could plausibly explain this observation, which therefore provides additional evidence that orca predation reduced the sea otter population.

D. If the orca population declined at the same time as the sea otter population, it would be less likely that increasing predation by orcas reduced the otter population.

E. Since the sea otters showed no signs of malnutrition, they were probably getting enough fish. But if they were not, commercial fishing rather than orcas might have caused the otter population decline.

The correct answer is C.

•

Political strategist: The domestic policies of our opponents in Party X are contrary to the priorities of many middle-class voters. Yet some of these same voters are supporters of Party X and its candidates due to the party's appeals about foreign policy. In order to win these voters back, we in Party Y must prove to middle-class voters that Party X does not represent their priorities with respect to domestic policy.

Which of the following would, if true, most strongly suggest that the political strategist's plan is unlikely to succeed?

A. Many in the middle class who support Party X for its foreign policies also support its domestic policies and are fully aware of the implications of those policies.

B. Most middle-class supporters of Party X care about foreign policy and know very little about its domestic policies.

C. Long-term domestic policy sometimes conflicts with short-term domestic policy.

D. There are topics on which Party X and Party Y have significant agreement.

E. Some middle-class voters are concerned about both domestic and foreign policy.

Evaluation of a Plan

Situation A political strategist for Party Y notes that the domestic policies of Party X are contrary to the priorities of middle-class voters. Many middle-class voters nonetheless support Party X because of its foreign policy. The strategist argues that to win these voters back, Party Y should prove to middle-class voters that Party X's domestic policies do not represent their priorities.

Reasoning *What claim would most strongly suggest that the strategist's plan will not succeed?* Suppose that a large number of the middle-class voters who support Party X's foreign policies also support its domestic policies, despite the fact that the domestic policies are contrary to their priorities. If that were true, then Party Y might well be unable to win back these voters by following the strategist's plan.

A. **Correct.** As noted above, if many middle-class voters who support Party X's foreign policies also support its domestic policies, the strategy of attempting to show these voters that there is a conflict between their priorities and Party X's domestic policies may well fail to get them to vote for Party Y. Presumably, these voters are aware of the conflict and support Party X nonetheless—perhaps because Party Y's domestic policies conflict with their priorities even more.

B. If most middle-class supporters of Party X know little about its domestic policies, Party Y may well be able to win them back simply by showing them the inconsistencies between those policies and their own priorities.

C. A conflict between long-term domestic policy and short-term domestic policy tells us nothing about whether educating middle-class voters about conflicts between their priorities and Party X's domestic policies would help

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educating middle class voters about conflicts between their priorities and Party Y's domestic policies would help win them back to Party Y.

D. The fact that the two parties have significant agreement on certain topics does not suggest the strategist's plan will not succeed. In fact, if the parties agreed on very little, the strategy of pointing only to issues related to domestic policy might be less likely to work. Therefore, this answer choice helps rule out a reason for thinking that the plan might not work.

E. If anything, this would help support the claim that the strategist's plan will succeed.

The correct answer is A.

•

Studies in restaurants show that the tips left by customers who pay their bill in cash tend to be larger when the bill is presented on a tray that bears a credit-card logo. Consumer psychologists hypothesize that simply seeing a credit-card logo makes many credit-card holders willing to spend more because it reminds them that their spending power exceeds the cash they have immediately available.

Which of the following, if true, most strongly supports the psychologists' interpretation of the studies?

A. The effect noted in the studies is not limited to patrons who have credit cards.

B. Patrons who are under financial pressure from their credit-card obligations tend to tip less when presented with a restaurant bill on a tray with a credit-card logo than when the tray has no logo.

C. In virtually all of the cases in the studies, the patrons who paid bills in cash did not possess credit cards.

D. In general, restaurant patrons who pay their bills in cash leave larger tips than do those who pay by credit card.

E. The percentage of restaurant bills paid with a given brand of credit card increases when that credit card's logo is displayed on the tray with which the bill is presented.

Argument Evaluation

Situation Studies have found that restaurant customers give more generous tips when their bills are brought on trays bearing a credit-card logo. Psychologists speculate that this is because the logo reminds customers of their ability to spend more money than they have.

Reasoning *Which of the options most helps to support the psychologists' explanation of the studies?* The psychologists' hypothesis is that the credit-card logos on the trays bring to the minds of those who tip more the fact that they have more purchasing power than merely the cash that they have at hand. This explanation would not be valid even if those people who are not reminded of their own excess purchasing power—if in fact they have any such power—when they see such a logo nonetheless tip more in such trays. Thus, if restaurant patrons who are under financial pressure from their credit-card obligations do not tip more when their bills are presented on trays bearing credit-card logos, then the psychologists' interpretation of the studies is supported.

A. This undermines the psychologists' interpretation, for it shows that the same phenomenon occurs even when the alleged cause has been removed.

B. **Correct.** If the consumer psychologists' hypothesis is true, it implies that only those who do, in fact, have additional spending power in the form of credit will be influenced by the logos to leave larger tips. If those who do not have such additional spending power are influenced in the same way, the hypothesis is flawed. Answer choice B indicates that the hypothesis is not flawed in this way, so it thereby tends to strengthen the hypothesis. It also strengthens the hypothesis by weakening some alternative hypotheses such as the following: Most of the customers who pay with cash do so because they have excessive credit-card debt and cannot use a credit card. However, seeing a credit-card logo makes them wonder whether credit-card customers may leave larger tips, and to avoid displeasing the server by leaving a small tip, they decide to leave a larger tip than they might otherwise have done.

C. This undermines the psychologists' interpretation by showing that the same phenomenon occurs even when the alleged cause has been removed; patrons cannot be reminded of something that is not there.

D. To the extent that this bears on the interpretation of the study, it weakens it. Patrons using credit cards are surely aware that they have credit, and yet they spend less generously.

E. This does not support the idea that being reminded that one has a credit card induces one to be more generous,

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E. This does not support the idea that being reminded that one has a credit card induces one to be more generous, only that it induces one to use that credit card.

The correct answer is B.

•

In an experiment, each volunteer was allowed to choose between an easy task and a hard task and was told that another volunteer would do the other task. Each volunteer could also choose to have a computer assign the two tasks randomly. Most volunteers chose the easy task for themselves and under questioning later said they had acted fairly. But when the scenario was described to another group of volunteers, almost all said choosing the easy task would be unfair. This shows that most people apply weaker moral standards to themselves than to others.

Which of the following is an assumption required by this argument?

A. At least some volunteers who said they had acted fairly in choosing the easy task would have said that it was unfair for someone else to do so.

B. The most moral choice for the volunteers would have been to have the computer assign the two tasks randomly.

C. There were at least some volunteers who were assigned to do the hard task and felt that the assignment was unfair.

D. On average, the volunteers to whom the scenario was described were more accurate in their moral judgments than the other volunteers were.

E. At least some volunteers given the choice between assigning the tasks themselves and having the computer assign them felt that they had made the only fair choice available to them.

Argument Construction

Situation In an experiment, most volunteers chose to do an easy task themselves and leave a hard task for someone else. They later said they had acted fairly, but almost all volunteers in another group to which the scenario was described said choosing the easy task would be unfair, indicating that most people apply weaker moral standards to themselves.

Reasoning *What must be true in order for the facts presented to support the conclusion that most people apply weaker moral standards to themselves than to others?* One set of volunteers said they had acted fairly in taking the easy task, whereas different volunteers said that doing so would be unfair. In neither case did any of the volunteers actually judge their own behavior differently from how they judged anyone else's. So, the argument implicitly infers from the experimental results that most of the volunteers would judge their own behavior differently from someone else's if given the chance. This inference assumes that the volunteers in the second group would have applied the same moral standards that those in the first group did if they had been in the first group's position, and vice versa.

A. **Correct.** If none of the volunteers who said their own behavior was fair would have judged someone else's similar behavior as unfair, then their relaxed moral judgment of themselves would not suggest that they applied weaker moral standards to themselves than to others.

B. Even if this is so, the experimental results could still suggest that the volunteers would apply weaker moral standards to themselves than to others.

C. The argument would be equally strong even if volunteers who were assigned the hard task did not know that someone else had gotten an easier task—or even if no volunteers were actually assigned the hard task at all.

D. Even if the moral standards applied by the volunteers who judged themselves were as accurate as those applied by the volunteers to whom the scenario was described, the former standards were still weaker.

E. Even if all the volunteers in the first group had felt that all the choices available to them would have been fair for them to make personally, they might have applied stricter moral standards to someone else in the same position.

The correct answer is A.

•

Country X's recent stock-trading scandal should not diminish investors' confidence in the country's stock market. For one thing, **the discovery of the scandal confirms that Country X has a strong regulatory system**, as the following considerations show. In any stock market, some fraudulent activity is inevitable. If a stock market is well regulated,

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any significant stock-trading fraud in it will very likely be discovered. This deters potential perpetrators and facilitates improvement in regulatory processes.

In the argument, the portion in **boldface** plays which of the following roles?

A. It is the argument's only conclusion.

B. It is a conclusion for which the argument provides support and which itself is used to support the argument's main conclusion.

C. It is the argument's main conclusion and is supported by another explicitly stated conclusion for which further support is provided.

D. It is an assumption for which no explicit support is provided and is used to support the argument's only conclusion.

E. It is a compound statement containing both the argument's main conclusion and an assumption used to support that conclusion.

Argument Construction

Situation Country X recently had a stock-trading scandal.

Reasoning *What role does the statement that the scandal's discovery confirms that Country X has a strong regulatory system play in the argument?* In the sentence containing the **boldfaced** statement, the phrase *For one thing* indicates that the statement is being used to justify the claim in the preceding sentence. Thus, the **boldfaced** statement must support that preceding sentence as a conclusion. Directly after the **boldfaced** statement, the phrase *as the following considerations show* indicates that the subsequent sentences are being used to support the **boldfaced** statement. Thus, the **boldfaced** statement is a conclusion supported by the sentences following it, and this statement itself supports the sentence preceding it, which must be the argument's main conclusion.

A. As explained above, the **boldfaced** statement supports the claim in the preceding sentence, so it cannot be the argument's only conclusion.

B. **Correct.** As explained above, the **boldfaced** statement is supported by the statements following it and in turn is used to support the argument's main conclusion in the statement preceding it.

C. As explained above, the **boldfaced** statement cannot be the argument's main conclusion, because it supports a further conclusion presented in the sentence preceding it.

D. As explained above, the sentences following the **boldfaced** statement are the explicit support provided for it.

E. As explained above, the argument's main conclusion is stated only in the first sentence, which precedes the **boldfaced** statement. It is not repeated anywhere in the **boldfaced** statement.

The correct answer is B.

•

Delta Products Inc. has recently switched at least partly from older technologies using fossil fuels to new technologies powered by electricity. The question has been raised whether it can be concluded that, **for a given level of output, Delta's operation now causes less fossil fuel to be consumed than it did formerly.** The answer, clearly, is yes, since the amount of fossil fuel used to generate the electricity needed to power the new technologies is less than the amount needed to power the older technologies, provided level of output is held constant.

In the argument given, the two **boldfaced** portions play which of the following roles?

A. The first identifies the content of the conclusion of the argument; the second provides support for that conclusion.

B. The first provides support for the conclusion of the argument; the second identifies the content of that conclusion.

C. The first states the conclusion of the argument; the second calls that conclusion into question.

D. The first provides support for the conclusion of the argument; the second calls that conclusion into question.

E. Each provides support for the conclusion of the argument.

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Argument Evaluation

Situation Delta switched from technologies using fossil fuels to ones using electricity. It has been asked whether this results in less fossil fuel used per level of output. The answer is that it does.

Reasoning *What roles do the two **boldfaced** portions play in the argument?* The first **boldfaced** statement is simply asserted by the passage; no premise, or reason, is given to support it. But the second **boldfaced** statement, when it is first introduced, is not asserted to be true, but rather is identified as something that might be inferred from the first statement. By the end of the passage, the argument concludes that the second statement is true.

A. This option simply reverses the roles that the statements play in the argument.

B. **Correct.** This option identifies the roles the **boldfaced** portions play: The second statement is not, on its own, the conclusion, because the argument initially merely *asks* whether it can be concluded on the basis of the first statement—that is, it asks whether the first **boldfaced** statement provides support for it. The conclusion of the argument is actually the statement *The answer, clearly, is yes*. The word *yes* is elliptical for *Yes, it can be concluded that for a given level of output, Delta's operation now causes less fossil fuel to be consumed than it did formerly*. The **boldfaced** portion tells us what can be concluded, and thus it can accurately be described as the content of the conclusion.

C. Nothing in the passage is intended to support the first statement, and the second statement is not supposed to call the first into question.

D. This correctly identifies the role of the first statement, but the second **boldfaced** portion does not call the argument's conclusion into question—it is part of a sentence that refers to the question whether that conclusion can be drawn from the first statement.

E. Again, this is only half right. The second **boldfaced** portion is not offered as support for the conclusion; if it were offered as such support, the argument would be guilty of circular reasoning, since the second **boldfaced** portion states exactly what the argument concludes.

The correct answer is B.

•

A product that represents a clear technological advance over competing products can generally command a high price. Because **technological advances tend to be quickly surpassed** and companies want to make large profits while they still can, many companies charge the greatest price the market will bear when they have such a product. But **large profits on the new product will give competitors a strong incentive to quickly match the new product's capabilities.** Consequently, the strategy to maximize overall profit from a new product is to charge less than the greatest possible price.

In the argument above, the two portions in **boldface** play which of the following roles?

A. The first is an assumption that forms the basis for a course of action that the argument criticizes; the second presents the course of action endorsed by the argument.

B. The first is a consideration raised to explain the appeal of a certain strategy; the second is a consideration raised to call into question the wisdom of adopting that strategy.

C. The first is an assumption that has been used to justify a certain strategy; the second is a consideration that is used to cast doubt on that assumption.

D. The first is a consideration raised in support of a strategy the argument endorses; the second presents grounds in support of that consideration.

E. The first is a consideration raised to show that adopting a certain strategy is unlikely to achieve the intended effect; the second is presented to explain the appeal of that strategy.

Argument Evaluation

Situation Companies generally charge the greatest price the market will bear when they have a product that represents a technological advance. This is because they want to make large profits while they can. But making large profits inspires competition. As a result, profits can be maximized by charging less than the greatest price possible.

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than the greatest price possible.

Reasoning *What logical roles do the two portions in **boldface** play in the argument?* The first sentence of the passage introduces a connection between technological advances and price. The second sentence discusses a pricing strategy related to such advances and offers certain considerations that help explain that strategy. The first **boldfaced** portion of the passage, which is contained in the second sentence, presents one of these considerations. The third sentence begins with the word *But*, which suggests that what follows—the second **boldfaced** section—presents a consideration that may be at least superficially at odds with the strategy just described. The final sentence of the argument presents an alternative strategy that is supported by the preceding discussion.

A. The course of action endorsed by the argument is described in the passage's fourth and final sentence, not in the second **boldfaced** portion, which is found in the passage's third sentence.

B. **Correct.** The first **boldfaced** portion is part of an explanation of why many companies follow the strategy of charging as much as the market will bear when they have a product representing a technological advance. The second **boldfaced** portion gives a reason not to follow that strategy.

C. The second **boldfaced** portion does not cast doubt on an assumption used to justify a strategy, but rather casts doubt on the strategy itself.

D. The first **boldfaced** portion is raised in support of a strategy that the argument calls into question, not a strategy that the argument endorses.

E. The first **boldfaced** portion helps explain the appeal of adopting a certain strategy; it does not show that the strategy is likely to fail. The second **boldfaced** portion does not explain the appeal of the strategy, but rather calls the strategy into question.

The correct answer is B.

•

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